

Intimacy for Chronic Pain

Pain shouldn't get the final say in how you connect.

Chronic pain can affect physical intimacy in ways that aren't always easy to talk about. Certain movements may become uncomfortable. Fatigue can also leave you with little energy for closeness at the end of the day.

Pain can also affect desire. Changes in libido, medication, stress, exhaustion, and the emotional toll of persistent pain can make intimacy feel very different from how it used to.

At Pain Clinic Australia, intimacy counselling provides a supportive space to explore these changes. Find ways of staying connected that work with your body, your relationship, and your current circumstances!

You don't have to let pain write the rules for your relationship.

[\[BOOK A SESSION\]](#)

When Pain Gets Between You

Sometimes the hardest part of chronic pain isn't the pain itself.

You may avoid physical closeness because certain movements are uncomfortable, or because you're worried about triggering a flare.

You may also be too exhausted to feel interested in intimacy at all.

And when these changes continue over time, they can affect both partners. Frustration, rejection, misunderstanding, and uncertainty can gradually create distance in even a loving relationship.

That doesn't mean you have stopped caring about each other.

It means chronic pain has introduced challenges that the two of you may need new ways of navigating.

How Intimacy Counselling Can Help

Intimacy counselling can help you and your partner navigate the relationship challenges that chronic pain can bring.

Depending on your needs, it may help you:

Adapt to physical limitations

Explore ways of maintaining physical closeness when certain movements or activities have become uncomfortable.

Navigate changes in desire

Understand and communicate about changes in desire without turning them into blame, pressure, or self-doubt.

Rebuild confidence

Work through body-image concerns and changes in physical confidence that may affect your willingness to be close.

Communicate your needs

Have more open conversations about comfort, boundaries, energy, expectations, and what feels right for both partners.

Work through relationship strain

Address the frustration, distance, or misunderstanding that can develop when chronic pain begins affecting a couple's connection.

Discover new ways to connect

Find practical approaches to intimacy that take your current body, energy, comfort, and circumstances into account.

What Happens During Intimacy Counselling?

Your sessions are tailored to your relationship, circumstances, and comfort level.

We will work with you to understand how chronic pain is affecting your connection and explore practical ways to address the challenges you're experiencing.

Sessions may include discussing:

- How pain affects physical closeness
- Changes in desire or libido
- Fatigue and its effect on relationships
- Body image and confidence
- Communication between partners
- Comfort, positioning, pacing, and physical limitations
- Ways to maintain connection during difficult periods
- Strategies for adapting intimacy around pain and changing energy levels

There is no expectation to perform, prove anything, or have all the answers.

The goal is to create a supportive space where you can talk openly about parts of your relationship that may be difficult to discuss elsewhere.

Finding What Works for You

Intimacy doesn't have to look exactly the way it did before chronic pain.

Sometimes the challenge is simply working out **how** to make physical closeness more comfortable.

You may need to experiment with different positions, pacing, timing, levels of activity, or ways of taking breaks when your energy runs low.

Our intimacy coaches can help you and your partner explore practical approaches that respect your comfort, physical limitations, energy levels, and boundaries.

[\[LEARN MORE\]](#)

Frequently Asked Questions

Can chronic pain really affect desire?

Yes. Pain, fatigue, stress, medication, emotional strain, changes in confidence, and relationship difficulties can all contribute to changes in desire. Intimacy counselling can

help you explore these changes and communicate about them with less pressure or uncertainty.

What if physical intimacy has become uncomfortable?

You don't have to simply accept discomfort or push through it. Counselling can help you explore practical ways of adapting physical closeness around your comfort, movement, energy, and symptoms.

What if I'm no longer confident in my body?

Changes caused by chronic pain can affect how you see yourself and how comfortable you feel being physically close to someone. These concerns are valid, and they can be explored in a supportive setting without judgement.

Do I need to attend with my partner?

Not necessarily. Depending on your circumstances and goals, sessions may be individual, with your partner, or involve a combination of both.

Is intimacy counselling only for couples?

No. You can seek support individually, whether you're currently in a relationship or simply want to better understand how chronic pain has affected your confidence, connection, or sense of intimacy.

Find Your Way Back to Closeness

Intimacy doesn't have to disappear just because your body has changed.

There may be things you used to enjoy that no longer feel comfortable. There may be days when you have the energy for closeness and days when you don't.

That doesn't mean your relationship has to become defined by what you can no longer do.

There are many ways to experience affection, closeness, pleasure, and connection.

The goal isn't to recreate exactly what your relationship looked like before chronic pain. It's to discover what works for **you now**.

One conversation, one connection, one step at a time.

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